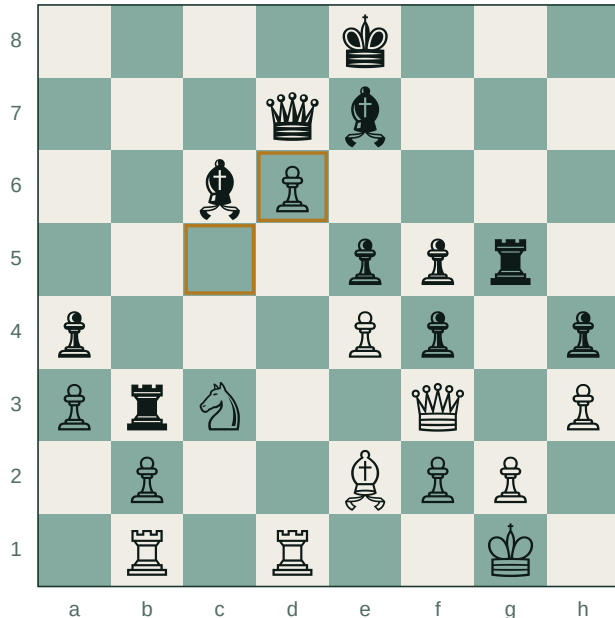


Trapping a piece: Black, move 33

Trapping a piece

Black to move



Previous move: 33.cxd6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

33...fxe4 34. Qh5+ Rxh5 35. Bxh5+ Kf8 36. dxe7+ Qxe7

33...fxe4 The pawn captures the pawn on e4. Recorded reply: **34.Qh5+**.

34...Rxh5 The rook captures the queen on h5. Recorded reply: **35.Bxh5+**.

35...Kf8 The king moves from e8 to f8. Recorded reply: **36.dxe7+**.

36...Qxe7 The queen captures the pawn on e7.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 22 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -2 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g1. Absolute pin: pawn on g2.